

THE gathering

A SIX WEEK JOURNEY THROUGH EPHESIANS

Who You Really Are

*Chosen. Adopted. Redeemed.
Raised. Seated. Filled.*

Pastor Billy Philips

THE GATHERING CTX · CLEBURNE, TEXAS

For our partners, with gratitude

A LETTER TO OUR PARTNERS

Friend,

Most of you already walked through this with us. You were in the room. You do not need a book to tell you what we studied.

But I wanted you to hold it.

My heart is simple. The tools we are learning while we study together, I want in your hands. Not a summary. The thing itself. Something you can say out loud, and keep, and come back to.

You stood with us through Ephesians. That means something to the leadership of this church. And what means something to them means something to me.

So here it is. Six weeks. Chosen. Adopted. Redeemed. Raised. Seated. Filled. Then the therefore. Now walk in it.

Grace be with you.

Pastor Billy Philips

The Gathering CTX, Cleburne, Texas

I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name.

WHAT IS INSIDE

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CLOSING: THE EPHESIANS DECREE

Blessed Before You Breathed

EPHESIANS 1:1 TO 14

The staggering grace of election and spiritual blessing.

Paul wrote Ephesians from prison. Roman chains. A dark cell. Awaiting possible execution. And from that place he writes what scholars call the most elevated, most exalted letter in the New Testament.

How does a man in chains write like a man in heaven?

Because Paul had discovered something that no chain, no prison, no emperor, and no circumstance could touch. He had discovered who he was in Christ. And once you know who you are in Christ, your geography becomes irrelevant.

The first fourteen verses of Ephesians 1 are perhaps the most compressed, most explosive statement of the believer's identity in the entire Bible. If these verses move from your head to your spirit, it will change everything about how you pray, how you live, how you fight, and how you worship.

You are blessed. Not because of what you did, but because of what He did before you ever existed.

God did not forgive you on a budget. He forgave you according to infinite riches.

Identity Over Circumstance

"Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God, To the saints who are in Ephesus, and are faithful in Christ Jesus: Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ."

EPHESIANS 1:1 TO 2 · ESV

Paul opens: "an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God." He does not open with complaint. He opens with identity. He is in prison, but he knows who he is. His circumstance has not overridden his calling.

Your assignment in the kingdom is not tied to your resume. It is tied to His grace. And His grace is sufficient for whatever He has called you to do.

Imagine a young man who has inherited a vast estate. But through a series of lies told to him in childhood, he believes he is a servant. He eats in the servant's quarters. He wears worn-out clothes. One day, the family attorney arrives and reads him the will: "You are the heir. Everything belongs to you." The heir does not become the heir when he hears the news. He already was. He simply did not know it. Ephesians 1 is God reading you His will.

Your situation does not define you. God defined you before your situation existed.

REFLECT

Have you been living as an heir or as a servant?

Every Spiritual Blessing Is Already Yours

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places."

EPHESIANS 1:3 • ESV

Past tense. Already done.

Paul is not saying God will eventually bless you if you try hard enough. He is saying God has already blessed you with everything in Christ before you walk out your front door this morning. Identity. Forgiveness. Access to the Father. Adoption. Redemption. Power. Purpose. Destiny. These are yours right now in Christ.

The Greek word *eulogētos* blessed comes from *eu* (well) and *logos* (word). God has spoken well over you. The blessings are spiritual blessings, meaning they originate in the Spirit, exist in the heavenly realm, and cannot be taken away by earthly circumstance.

Imagine you receive a notice from a bank that an account was opened in your name twenty years ago and has been accruing interest ever since. You had no idea it existed. You have been working double shifts to pay rent, eating ramen, barely surviving, when the entire time there was an account with your name on it, full and waiting. Ephesians 1:3 is that notice.

You are not begging for what God has already given. You are learning to walk in it.

REFLECT

What old identity have you been carrying that God erased before you were born?

Chosen Before the Foundation of the World

"Even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him."

EPHESIANS 1:4 · ESV

Before the first photon of light. Before the first breath of the first human. God chose you in Christ.

This is meant to produce security and worship. If God chose you before you existed, before you did anything good or bad, then your standing before Him is not based on your performance. It is based on His purpose.

The Greek word *eklegō* to choose, to select describes deliberate, purposeful selection. You were not an accident in the mind of God. You were a deliberate choice. Before you had a name, God already knew yours.

You cannot earn what God decided before you were born.

REFLECT

What would change if you truly believed the blessing is already yours?

Adopted, Not Just Pardoned

"In love he predestined us for adoption to himself as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will, to the praise of his glorious grace."

EPHESIANS 1:5 TO 6 · ESV

God did not just pardon you. He adopted you.

A pardon says: your charges are dropped, you may go. Adoption says: you are now my child, you belong in my family, my name is your name, my house is your house, my inheritance is your inheritance.

Sons live differently than strangers. Sons pray differently. Sons carry the Father's name with authority. Sons do not beg at the door of a house they own.

The Greek word *huiothesia* adoption carries immense legal weight. In Roman law, adoption gave the adopted child all the rights of a biological son, including inheritance, the family name, and legal standing. Once adopted, the old debts and obligations of the previous life were completely erased.

That is your legal standing in Christ.

God did not just pardon you from your past. He adopted you into His future.

REFLECT

Sit with this: God did not just pardon you from your past. He adopted you into His future.

Redeemed According to Riches, Not Reserves

"In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace, which he lavished upon us."

EPHESIANS 1:7 TO 8 · ESV

Not according to the measure of your faith. According to the riches of His grace.

When a billionaire gives a gift, he does not give according to your budget. He gives according to his resources. God does not forgive you according to what your repentance deserves. He forgives you according to the infinite riches of His grace.

The Greek word *apolytrōsis* redemption literally means "a releasing for a ransom." In the ancient world, it was used for the buying back of slaves or prisoners of war. The price has been paid. The papers have been signed. You have been purchased and set free.

REFLECT

What is God saying to you in this? Write it down before you move on.

A PRAYER OF IDENTITY

Father, I receive what You have spoken over me. I was chosen before the foundation of the world. I am blessed with every spiritual blessing in Christ. I am not an accident. I am not defined by my history, my failures, or my feelings. I am defined by what You decided before time began. I lay down the old identity today. I receive the new one, not because of what I have done, but because of what You did before I was born. I am Your child. I carry Your name. I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen.

CLOSING DECLARATION

I am chosen in Christ before the foundation of the world. I am blessed with every spiritual blessing in heavenly places. I am adopted as a son of the living God. I am redeemed according to the riches of His grace, not the poverty of my performance. My identity is in Christ Jesus, settled before time began. I walk with victory, not to it.

Now go chosen, blessed, adopted, and redeemed. May the God who selected you before the foundation of the world keep you this week from forgetting your name. May the Father who lavished His grace upon you in Christ remind you every morning that the blessing is not coming. It is already yours. Go and live like it. Amen

Brought Near by the Blood

EPHESIANS 2:13 TO 22

You were far off. You were dead. But God, rich in mercy, brought you near.

There is a word in Scripture that changes everything. It is small, but it carries the full weight of heaven. The word is but.

You were dead in your trespasses. You were far off. You were without God and without hope. But. That single word is the hinge on which eternity swings. Because the gospel is not about making bad people good. The gospel is about making dead people alive. You were either dead or you are alive. And dead people cannot self-correct. Dead people must be resurrected.

No self-help. Only God's help. Only through the blood.

The gospel is not about making bad people good. It is about making dead people alive.

The Blood Brought You Near

"But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ."

EPHESIANS 2:13 • ESV

Again there is hope when we see that powerful word but. We have been brought near by the blood of Christ. Without the blood the payment would still be owed. Without it we are far off, lost, broken, and in despair.

But the blood has brought us near. Christ's precious, perfect blood gave us peace. It broke down the works of the flesh and sin. It did what no amount of effort, religion, or moral improvement could ever do. It closed the distance between a holy God and a fallen people.

The Greek word haima (αἷμα) blood in the New Testament is not merely biological. It represents the total sacrifice of Christ, the giving of His life as the payment that satisfied the justice of God. When Paul says we are brought near "by the blood," he is declaring that access to the Father was purchased at the highest cost and given as the freest gift.

You did not earn proximity to God. You were bought into it.

REFLECT

Have I been trying to earn what the blood already purchased?

The Wall Is Down

"For he himself is our peace, who has made us both one and has broken down in his flesh the dividing wall of hostility."

EPHESIANS 2:14 • ESV

His blood has unified us with God through the cross. Not only Gentiles, but also Jews. Those far off and those who are near are all in the same position. All have the same solution: the blood of Jesus, the payment at the cross.

In the ancient temple in Jerusalem there was a literal wall, a barrier that separated the Court of the Gentiles from the inner courts. A sign on that wall warned that any non-Jew who passed beyond it would be responsible for their own death. That wall said: you do not belong here. You are outside.

Christ demolished that wall. Not with a political movement. Not with a reformation. With His body and His blood. He did not simply open a door. He tore down the entire structure of separation. In its place He created something entirely new.

REFLECT

Am I living as a stranger when God has already made me a citizen?

One New Humanity

"That he might create in himself one new man in place of the two, so making peace, and might reconcile us both to God in one body through the cross, thereby killing the hostility."

EPHESIANS 2:15 TO 16 · ESV

Not only did the blood unify us with God, but one another. Verse 15 talks about making one new man out of two. This is not a merger. This is a creation. Something that did not exist before now exists because of the cross.

The Greek word *kainos* (καινός) new in kind, not just in time tells us this "new man" is not a renovation. It is not the old thing repaired. It is a brand new category of humanity. People who were once divided by law, ethnicity, history, and hostility are now fused together into a single body through the cross of Jesus Christ.

This is what the Church is. Not an institution. Not a building. A new humanity, created by the blood, held together by the Spirit, and built on the foundation of Christ Himself.

You are not a stranger. You are not an outsider. You are a citizen, a member, an heir.

REFLECT

Where in my life am I still relying on self-help instead of surrendering to the resurrection power of Christ?

No Longer Strangers

"So then you are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God."

EPHESIANS 2:19 • ESV

No longer strangers or aliens but fellow citizens and members. Not just customary privileges. We are adopted into the family, given the name, and granted full protections and rights. This is not guest access. This is sonship. This is inheritance. This is belonging at the deepest level.

Think of it this way: an immigrant with temporary papers lives in a country but does not carry its full identity. They can be present without being permanent. But citizenship changes everything. Citizenship means the nation claims you, protects you, and calls you its own. That is what God has done for you through the blood. He has not merely allowed you to visit His presence. He has made you a permanent member of His household.

You belong. Not because of what you have done. Because of what He has done.

REFLECT

What is God saying to you in this? Write it down before you move on.

Built Into a Holy Temple

"Built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone, in whom the whole structure, being joined together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord. In him you also are being built together into a dwelling place for God by the Spirit."

EPHESIANS 2:20 TO 22 • ESV

Jesus is the foundation. Jesus is the cornerstone. And He joins all the Church together, growing as His Holy Temple in whom He is pleased to dwell by the Spirit that He places in us.

The cornerstone in ancient construction was the first stone laid. Every other stone was measured and aligned according to it. If the cornerstone was off, the entire building was off. Jesus Christ is the standard, the alignment, the reference point for everything the Church is and everything we become.

And notice: this temple is not static. It is growing. You are not a finished product. You are a living stone being shaped, positioned, and joined together with other believers into something that displays the presence of God. The Spirit dwells not in a building made with hands, but in a people made by blood.

REFLECT

What is God saying to you in this? Write it down before you move on.

A PRAYER OF IDENTITY

Father, I was dead. I was far off. I was without hope. But You, rich in mercy, brought me near by the blood of Your Son. I did not earn this. I could not earn this. I receive it. I am no longer a stranger. I am no longer an outsider. I am a citizen of Your kingdom, a member of Your household, a living stone in Your holy temple. I renounce every attempt to save myself, fix myself, or earn what Christ already purchased. I stand in the finished work of the cross. The blood is enough. The blood has always been enough. I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen.

Go now as one who belongs. Go as a citizen, not a stranger. Go as a living stone, joined to other stones, growing into a holy dwelling for the presence of God. The blood that brought you near is the same blood that sends you out. You carry the peace of Christ into every room, every conversation, every moment. You are alive. You are near. You are His. I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen

The Mystery Is Out

EPHESIANS 3:1 TO 21

The excluded are included. The strangers are now sons.

Ephesians 3 is one of the most breathtaking chapters in the entire Bible. Paul, writing from a prison cell, calls himself "a prisoner of Christ Jesus" and then launches into a revelation so staggering he has to interrupt himself to make sure you understand what you are hearing.

He is revealing what he calls the mystery. In the New Testament, a mystery is not something impossible to know. It is something that was hidden and has now been revealed.

And the mystery of Ephesians 3 is this: Gentiles, outsiders, those who had no claim, are now fellow heirs, members of the same body, and partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus. The wall is down. The excluded are included. The strangers are now sons. The mystery is out.

Grace does not choose the most qualified. It qualifies the chosen.

Grace Qualifies the Chosen

"To me, though I am the very least of all the saints, this grace was given, to preach to the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ."

EPHESIANS 3:8 • ESV

Paul describes himself as "the very least of all the saints" and yet he was the one entrusted with this mystery. He did not volunteer. He was a persecutor of the church. He was the last person anyone would have picked.

But that is how grace works. Grace does not choose the most qualified. It qualifies the chosen. God does not call those who are ready. He makes ready those He calls.

Your assignment in the Kingdom is not tied to your resume. It is tied to His grace. And His grace is sufficient for whatever He has called you to do.

The Greek word *oikonomia* (οἰκονομία) stewardship literally means "the law of the household." Paul was entrusted with a specific management responsibility: to make known the mystery. Every believer carries a stewardship, a portion of God's work entrusted specifically to them.

REFLECT

Have I been living like an outsider, as if the promises of God are for everyone else but not fully for me?

What stewardship has God entrusted specifically to me? Am I walking in it?

The Church: God's Display Case

"So that through the church the manifold wisdom of God might now be made known to the rulers and authorities in the heavenly places."

EPHESIANS 3:10 • ESV

Through the church. Not through angels. Not through the sun, the stars, or the heavens. Through the church.

The church, this gathered, imperfect, diverse, Spirit-filled assembly of people who have nothing in common except the blood of Jesus, is God's chosen display case of His wisdom to the unseen world.

When the church loves across racial divides, God puts His wisdom on display. When the church forgives the unforgivable, God puts His wisdom on display. When the church holds together in unity across culture and background, principalities and powers see something they cannot explain.

The Greek word *polupoikilos* (πολυποίκιλος) manifold, many-colored was used of embroidery with many patterns and colors woven together. God's wisdom is not monochrome. It is displayed through the diverse, unified, Spirit-knit body of believers. Every background, every nation, every story woven together into one tapestry of grace.

The church is not just a meeting place. It is a cosmic announcement.

REFLECT

How does being part of the church, God's display case, change the way I see Sunday gatherings?

A Prayer for Fullness, Not Comfort

"That according to the riches of his glory he may grant you to be strengthened with power through his Spirit in your inner being, so that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith."

EPHESIANS 3:16 TO 17 · ESV

Paul falls to his knees and prays. Not for their circumstances, not for their finances, not for their health. He prays that they would be strengthened in the inner person. That Christ would dwell in their hearts through faith. That they would be rooted and grounded in love. That they would comprehend the incomprehensible love of Christ. That they would be filled with all the fullness of God.

This is not a small prayer. This is not a comfortable prayer. This is a transformational prayer.

He prays that they would know what surpasses knowledge. That is not a contradiction. It is a paradox of grace. The love of Christ is so vast that it cannot be contained in theological categories. It must be experienced.

Not 10 percent of God. Not enough to be religious. All the fullness. The same word used when Scripture says the earth is full of the glory of God. That is what God wants to pour into His people.

God is not trying to give you enough. He is trying to fill you until you overflow.

REFLECT

Where have I been asking God for "enough" instead of asking Him for fullness?

Far More Abundantly

"Now to him who is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think, according to the power at work within us, to him be glory in the church and in Christ Jesus throughout all generations, forever and ever. Amen."

EPHESIANS 3:20 TO 21 · ESV

This is Paul's doxology, his burst of praise. And it is perhaps the most expansive promise in the Bible about God's ability.

Far more abundantly. Not a little more. Not double. Far more abundantly than all that we ask, and not just ask, but think. Even your imagination does not reach the ceiling of what God is able to do.

The limitation is never on God's side. The power is at work within us and it is limitless. The question is not what God can do. The question is what we are willing to believe and yield to.

You have not yet asked for too much. You have probably asked for too little.

REFLECT

What would I ask for if I truly believed God could do far more abundantly than I could imagine?

A PRAYER OF IDENTITY

Father, thank You that the mystery is out. I am a fellow heir, a member of Your body, a partaker of the promise. Strengthen me with power in my inner being. Let Christ dwell in my heart through faith. Root me and ground me in love. Help me comprehend the breadth and length and height and depth of Your love that surpasses knowledge. Fill me with all Your fullness, not a portion, but all of You. Do far more abundantly than I could ever ask or imagine. In Jesus' name. Amen.

The mystery of Christ is in me and I am in Him. I am a fellow heir, a member of His body, a partaker of the promise. I am filled, not halfway, not enough to get by, but with all the fullness of God. My God is able to do far more abundantly than everything I have asked or imagined, according to His power that is already at work within me. I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name. Amen

Walk Worthy: Inside and Out

EPHESIANS 4:1 TO 32

The therefore of the whole letter. Now walk in it.

Scripture Reading "I therefore, a prisoner for the Lord, urge you to walk in a manner worthy of the calling to which you have been called, with all humility and gentleness, with patience, bearing with one another in love, eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace." Ephesians 4:1 to 3

Therefore

For three weeks we have been diving into who we really are. Week 1: Before you drew a breath, God chose you. Adopted you. Blessed you with every spiritual blessing in heavenly places. Week 2: You were dead. But God, rich in mercy, great in love, made you alive, raised you up, and seated you with Christ. Week 3: The mystery is out. The wall is down. You are a fellow heir, a member of His body, a partaker of the promise, filled with all the fullness of God.

Three weeks of the most exhilarating theology in the New Testament. Chosen. Adopted. Redeemed. Raised. Seated. Filled.

And now Paul says one word: Therefore.

In the Bible, when you see the word "therefore," you stop and ask: what is it there for? It is there for everything Paul has just said. Chapter 4 is the therefore of the entire letter. It is where Paul takes everything he has built and says: now walk in it.

Ephesians 4 has two movements. And you need both. The first half is the corporate call: walk worthy together, maintain the unity, take your place in the body, grow up. The second half is the personal exchange: take off what is dead, put on what is new, walk worthy on the inside. Same chapter. Same call. Inside and out.

"The Christian life is not behavior modification. It is identity manifestation."

REFLECT

Does your Monday match your Sunday? Where is your walk out of balance with your identity?

The Corporate Call: How We Walk Together

DAY 02

Walk in a Way That Matches Your Name

Remember where Paul is writing from. Chains. A Roman prison. Not a man speaking from comfort or security. A prisoner. Writing about walking. Paul is physically not walking anywhere. He is in chains. And from that place, he urges the church to walk worthy. Because he has discovered that your circumstances, your chains, your setbacks, your limitations, cannot stop the walk he is talking about.

The walk Paul means is not the walk of your feet. It is the walk of your life.

Now let's get the word "worthy" right. Because someone reading this is already feeling the weight of unworthiness. Let me take that pressure off. Worthy does not mean perfect. It means proportionate. It means your walk matches your talk. Your conduct matches your confession. Your Monday matches your Sunday.

This is not performance based Christianity. It is identity based living. You are not walking worthy to earn grace. You are walking worthy because of grace. The grace came first. Now the walk follows.

axios (ἄξιος) "Worthy," from the root meaning to weigh. The image is a scale in balance. Walk axios means walk proportionately, your daily life carrying the same weight as your identity in Christ. Not heavier. Not lighter. Balanced

REFLECT

Are you actively maintaining unity, or passively allowing division to grow? Is there an offense you need to release?

Unity Is Maintained, Not Created

Notice the word: maintain. Not create. Not manufacture. Maintain. The Holy Spirit has already produced the unity. He wove it together in the blood of Jesus Christ. Your job is to keep it. To guard it.

And Paul is specific about how. Not through willpower. Not through programs. Through humility. Gentleness. Patience. Bearing with one another in love. In a Roman culture that worshipped power and self promotion, these were radical acts of spiritual warfare.

Look at verses 4 through 6. Paul gives them the foundation: one body, one Spirit, one hope, one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all. Seven ones. You cannot be unified in seven dimensions and divided in your row. The things that divide us are almost never the seven ones. They are preferences. Offenses. Pride.

spoudazō (σπουδάζω) "Eager, diligent, making every effort," used in verse 3. This word carries urgency. It is not casual. Paul is saying: urgently, earnestly, with your whole effort, maintain the unity. Division in the body of Christ is not just a social problem. It is a spiritual emergency

"Unity is not accidental. It is chosen by people who choose humility over being right."

REFLECT

Is your gift being used to build the body, or is it sitting unused? What would it look like to take your place?

The Body Needs What You Carry

When Christ ascended, He did not leave the church empty handed. He gave gifts: apostles, prophets, evangelists, shepherds, teachers. But notice what they are for. Not performance. Not platform. Not popularity. Equipping. The gifts are tools. And tools exist to build something greater than themselves.

A minister who uses their gift to build a following rather than build the body has missed the point entirely. Every gift is given downward to serve, to equip, to build.

And here is the part that liberates every person who does not preach, does not play an instrument, and does not lead anything visible: every member has a gift. The body only reaches full maturity when every part is functioning in its right place. Your gift is structural. The body needs what you carry. When you keep it hidden, the body limps.

katartismos (καταρτισμός) "Equipping," used in verse 12.

This word was used in medicine for setting a broken bone, in fishing for mending the nets, in military contexts for fully outfitting a soldier. God is setting you, mending you, outfitting you. Not so you can sit in a pew. So you can take your place

REFLECT

What part of the old wardrobe is still hanging in your closet? What needs to come off today?

Maturity Means Being Anchored

The goal of all the gifts, all the equipping, all the building is the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ. Paul is not aiming at better behavior. He is not aiming at nicer, more disciplined, more respectable people. He is aiming at something far more staggering: a people who collectively, together, as a joined body, reflect the character, the nature, the life of Jesus Christ in the earth.

Paul paints two pictures. And you need to decide which one describes you right now. Picture one: children, tossed to and fro by the waves, carried by every wind of doctrine, destabilized by one bad conversation, blown around by the voice of whoever spoke to them last. Picture two: people rooted in Christ, speaking truth in love, growing up in every way into Him who is the head.

The difference is not age. Not how long you have been in church. Spiritual immaturity is not mainly a lack of knowledge but a lack of anchoring. Mature believers still face storms, yet they are not swept away because their roots run deep.

REFLECT

Is there unresolved anger or bitterness you have carried past sundown? What would it take to deal with it tonight?

The Personal Exchange: How We Walk on the Inside

DAY 06

That Is Not Who You Are

Paul moves from addressing the community as a whole to speaking directly to each person. He describes the old walk: futility of mind, darkened understanding, hardness of heart, given over to sensuality. Watch how the progression moves: Futility of mind leads to darkened understanding. Darkened understanding leads to hardness of heart. Hardness of heart leads to being given over. Sin does not stay where it starts. What begins as a temptation becomes a habit. What begins as a habit becomes a callus. What begins as a callus becomes a lifestyle.

But Paul does not leave them there. He never leaves them there. Verse 20: "But that is not the way you learned Christ."

Five words that change everything. That is not who you are. That is not what you were taught. That is not the life you were raised into. You learned Christ. And Christ does not walk in futility. Christ does not live in darkness. Christ is not callous. And if you are in Christ, neither are you.

pōrōsis (πώρωσις) "Hardness," a medical term for the formation of a callus. Skin wounded so many times it no longer feels. Sin does not just damage us. Over time, it numbs us. What shocked us once no longer registers. That is the warning Paul is sounding

"The old man does not live here anymore. Stop letting him sleep on the couch."

REFLECT

How are you honoring the Holy Spirit who sealed you? Or how have you grieved Him?

The Exchange: Put Off, Be Renewed, Put On

Paul gives us one of the clearest pictures in all of Scripture: the exchange. Put off. Be renewed. Put on. Not complicated. But not passive.

The old self is not ripped off you automatically at salvation. Paul is addressing believers. He tells them to take it off. Actively. Daily. Here is the illustration. A man comes to Christ. Genuinely saved. Genuinely transformed. But he still has the old wardrobe hanging in his closet. Old habits. Old thought patterns. Old relational dynamics. Old addictions. Old anger. Old insecurities. He does not have to wear them anymore. They have no claim on him. The blood of Jesus purchased his freedom from every one of them. But nobody is making him throw them away. Paul says: you have to do that. Actively. Deliberately.

And here is what you cannot miss about the "put on." The new self is not a better version of you. It is participation in Christ Himself. When you put on the new self, you are not upgrading your personality. You are clothing yourself in the nature and life of Jesus Christ. This is not self improvement. This is transformation from the inside out, through union with a living Person.

apotithēmi (ἀποτίθημι) and endyō (ἐνδύω) "Put off" and "Put on." Apotithēmi is the same word used for taking off old clothes. Deliberate. Intentional. Endyō is used for dressing yourself, for soldiers putting on armor. The new self is not something that descends on you passively. You put it on. Every morning. Like armor. Like a decision

REFLECT

What is God saying to you in this? Write it down before you move on.

Walk It Out in the Specific

Paul does not let us stay in abstraction. He brings it into the house. Into the marriage. Into the workplace. Into the conversation you had on the way to church this morning.

Put away falsehood. Let each one of you speak the truth with his neighbor, for we are members one of another. Truth is the oxygen of a healthy church. When you cut off the oxygen, the body suffocates.

Deal with anger before the sun goes down. Paul does not say anger is a sin. He says do not let it stay. Do not let it sleep. Because every night you go to sleep with unresolved anger, you hand the enemy a key to a room in your house.

Let no corrupting talk come out of your mouth. The word corrupting is *sapros* in Greek, the same word used for rotten fruit. Words that decay the people around you. Your words should leave people with more grace than they had before you opened your mouth.

Put away bitterness, wrath, anger, clamor, slander, and malice. Bitterness is the slow poison. It starts with a wound, grows in silence, quietly colors everything. It will make you see enemies everywhere until the only enemy left is the one in the mirror. Put it away. Not because the person who hurt you deserves your forgiveness. But because bitterness is destroying you. And you are too valuable to be destroyed by something you have the power to release.

Be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ forgave you. The capacity to forgive is not found in your willpower. It is found in the revelation of how much you have been forgiven. Forgive as you have been forgiven. That is the worthy walk.

REFLECT

What is God saying to you in this? Write it down before you move on.

Do Not Grieve the Holy Spirit

"And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption."

Pause here. This matters. The Holy Spirit can be grieved. Not as a mere theological idea but as a relational reality. Only someone who loves you can be hurt. Indifference, contracts, and machines cannot be grieved. But a person can. The Holy Spirit, who lives in every believer, sealed you at salvation, and serves as God's down payment on His promises, is a person. And He can be wounded.

The text warns that sins like lying, corrupt speech, bitterness, and anger deeply grieve the Holy Spirit. Paul grounds the warning in the Spirit's role as the seal of the new covenant, the mark of God's ownership, the guarantee of His promises, the down payment of our eternal inheritance. Grieving Him is not merely relational hurt. It is living out of step with the covenant reality we have been brought into.

In response to His steady faithfulness through every season and failure, we should honor Him by putting off what grieves Him and putting on what pleases Him.

lypeō (λυπέω) "To cause grief, pain, or sorrow," the same word used when Jesus was in agony in Gethsemane. The Holy Spirit is not distant. He is present. And He feels

REFLECT

What is God saying to you in this? Write it down before you move on.

A PRAYER OF IDENTITY

Father, thank You for my identity in Christ. Help me walk worthy of the calling You have placed on my life, not to earn it, but because of it. Give me humility to maintain unity. Show me where my gift fits in the body. Help me put off everything that belongs to the old self and put on the new self, not a better version of me, but Christ formed in me. Renew my mind in Your Word. Help me deal with anger before the sun goes down and release every root of bitterness. I do not want to grieve the Spirit who sealed me. Let my walk match my name, inside and out. In Jesus' name, Amen.

CLOSING DECLARATION

I walk worthy of my calling, not to earn it, but because of it! I maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace! I put off the old self. It has no dominion over me! I am renewed in the spirit of my mind by the Word of God! I put on the new self, not a better version of me, but Christ formed in me! I speak truth. I deal with anger before the sun goes down. I let no corrupt talk come out of my mouth, only words that give grace. I do not grieve the One who sealed me into covenant! I put away bitterness, wrath, anger, slander, and malice, all of it! And I put on kindness, tenderheartedness, and forgiveness, as God in Christ forgave me! The Christian life is not behavior modification. It is identity manifestation! I walk with victory, not to it. Amen!

WEEK 5

Walk in Love, Light, and Wisdom

EPHESIANS 5:1 TO 33

Imitate God. Walk as children of light. Be filled with the Spirit.

"Therefore be imitators of God, as beloved children. And walk in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God."

EPHESIANS 5:1 TO 2 • ESV

Imitate God and Walk as Children of Light

DAY 01

Be Imitators of God

This is one of the most breathtaking commands in all of Scripture. Imitate God. Not imitate a good pastor. Not imitate a respected elder. Not imitate a disciplined believer you admire. Imitate God.

And before the weight of that crushes you, Paul gives you the foundation: as beloved children.

Children imitate their Father. Not by straining and performing, but by proximity and relationship. A child does not sit down in the morning and say: today I will mimic my father's character through concentrated effort. They simply absorb it. Naturally. Over time. Because they are with him. Because they love him. Because they belong to him.

This is the model. Not performance. Proximity. Relationship. Love.

And then Paul defines what Godlike love actually looks like in practice: walk in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us. A fragrant offering. A sacrifice. The love of God is not sentimental. It is sacrificial. It does not look for what it can receive. It looks for what it can give, even at cost to itself. Even at infinite cost.

μιμητής (mimētēs), "Imitator," the word we get "mimic" from. It implies careful, sustained, intentional modeling of someone else's behavior and character. This is not casual imitation. It is discipleship at its deepest level, becoming so familiar with how God acts that His ways become your natural response.

REFLECT

What would it look like to imitate God in the ordinary moments of your week, not just the big spiritual ones?

What Must Not Even Be Named

Paul does not soften this. Sexual immorality. All impurity. Covetousness. Filthiness. Foolish talk. Crude joking. Must not even be named among you.

Paul says: that is not who you are anymore. Stop calling it normal. Stop making peace with what God calls darkness.

When the Spirit feels distant and prayer or worship feels heavy, it may be because we have allowed things into our inner life that no longer belong to who we are in Christ. Not in condemnation, but in love, calling us to put them away.

Paul warns not to be deceived by "empty words" that claim our conduct does not matter or that grace makes holiness optional. Grace is not a license to sin. It is God's power to help us become what He says we already are.

A flashlight does not argue with the darkness. It simply turns on.

REFLECT

Is there anything in your life that "must not even be named" among saints that you have been making peace with?

You Were Darkness. Now You Are Light.

Paul's wording emphasizes identity, not surroundings: apart from Christ, people were not merely in darkness. They were darkness. Likewise, believers are not simply placed in light or gradually becoming brighter. In the Lord they are light, because the One who is Light now lives in them.

And light does two things. It reveals and it produces.

Reveal: In the presence of light, darkness cannot hide. Paul says expose the works of darkness, not by pointing fingers, not by mounting a campaign. By shining. A flashlight does not argue with the darkness. It simply turns on.

Produce: The fruit of light is found in all that is good and right and true. Where light is present, things grow. The life of a believer walking in the light is a productive life. The fruit, goodness, righteousness, truth, is not manufactured. It is grown in the light.

And then verse 14, an early Christian hymn embedded in the middle of the text: "Awake, O sleeper, and arise from the dead, and Christ will shine on you."

This is an altar call hiding in the theology. Someone reading this is spiritually asleep. Not dead, asleep. Drifted. Numbed by the slow anesthesia of routine, compromise, and making peace with the wrong things. Present in the pew but not producing fruit. Alive but not awake. Awake, O sleeper. The light of Christ is shining right now. You do not have to stay in the drift. Arise.

φῶς (phōs), "Light," in the ancient world associated with truth, revelation, and divine presence. God is light. Darkness is not merely the absence of light. It is the domain of deception and spiritual bondage. Walking as children of light means we carry the nature of the God who is light. Wherever we go, we do not just brighten the atmosphere. We carry a Person.

REFLECT

Are you spiritually awake or spiritually asleep? What would it take to arise?

Walk in Wisdom and Be Filled with the Spirit

DAY 04

Look Carefully How You Walk

Paul shifts from what we walk away from to how we walk. And he uses a word that demands attention: carefully. Not casually. Not reactively. Not simply following the current that everyone else is following. Carefully. With precision. With intention. With eyes open.

Because the days are evil. That is not pessimism. That is discernment. The days we live in are not neutral. There are forces at work in this cultural moment that are intentionally designed to pull you away from the life God has for you. An unintentional believer in an intentionally dark culture will lose ground without ever realizing it.

And verse 17: understand what the will of the Lord is. Paul is not sending you on an anxious treasure hunt for a hidden divine roadmap. He has spent five chapters telling you the will of God. Walk worthy. Love your neighbor. Walk in the light. Be filled with the Spirit. The will of God is not hidden. The call is to live aligned with what has already been written.

καιρός (kairos), "The appointed, strategic, Spirit marked moment," distinct from *chronos*, the steady tick of ordinary time. Make the best use of the kairos moments: the open doors, the divine appointments, the opportunities to speak truth, extend grace, and carry the gospel into places that need it. These moments are finite. Do not sleepwalk through them.

You do not fill yourself with the Spirit. You yield to the Spirit who is already in you. The overflow is His work. Your part is surrender.

REFLECT

Are you being filled with the Spirit continuously, or only occasionally?
What does daily surrender look like for you?

Be Filled with the Spirit

Paul's practical teaching reaches its climax in the command to "be filled with the Spirit," not as a one time experience, but an ongoing, moment by moment dependence that answers the deep human emptiness the world tries to satisfy with lesser substitutes.

Only God's Spirit can fill what God created, and that continual filling produces a distinct kind of life: everyday worship that overflows into song, sincere heart level devotion, constant gratitude in all circumstances, and humble mutual submission out of reverence for Christ.

The Spirit does not just fill the Sunday moments. He fills the Monday ordinary. He is not a weekend presence. He is a continuously available, inexhaustible reservoir of everything you need. You do not fill yourself with the Spirit. You yield to the Spirit who is already in you. The overflow is His work. Your part is surrender.

πληρόω (plēroō), "To fill," present tense, passive voice, imperative. Be continuously being filled. The same word from Ephesians 3:19: "filled with all the fullness of God." Rather than a weekend only presence, the Spirit is a continuously available, inexhaustible reservoir, and our role is not to fill ourselves but to yield in surrender so His overflow can shape our ordinary days.

REFLECT

If you are married: what is your marriage preaching to the people around you? Is your spouse flourishing because of your love?

The Holy Marriage: A Living Picture of Christ and the Church

DAY 06

The Mystery of Marriage

Paul is not primarily writing a marriage manual. He is writing about Christ and the church and he uses marriage as the living illustration. Even more, he uses the mystery of Christ's covenant love to redefine what marriage is supposed to be.

Marriage does not invent the picture of how Jesus treats his people. It is meant to become the visible, embodied display of how Jesus already loves the church. In other words, your marriage is never merely private. It is a public proclamation, a living sermon, announcing the fierce, faithful, covenant love of Christ for his bride.

REFLECT

What is God saying to you in this? Write it down before you move on.

Wives: Honor the Covenant

Paul is not asking wives to submit to every man, or to a husband who has not earned it, or to abuse or neglect. He is describing the dynamic within a healthy, Christ centered covenant where the husband is serving his wife the way Christ serves the church.

And here is the key: Paul addresses wives in three verses. He addresses husbands in nine. Because the standard Paul places on husbands is far more demanding than anything he asks of wives. If a husband is loving his wife the way Christ loved the church, giving himself up for her, nourishing her, cherishing her, sanctifying her, the submission of a wife is not a burden. It is a response to love.

ὑποτάσσω (hypotassō), "Submit," a military term meaning to arrange oneself under the authority of another. But in the New Testament it carries the idea of voluntary, willing deference, not coerced servitude. This is the same word used in verse 21 for mutual submission: "submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ."

REFLECT

What is God saying to you in this? Write it down before you move on.

Husbands: Love as Christ Loved

This is one of the most demanding verses ever directed at husbands. Love your wives as Christ loved the church.

How did Christ love the church? He gave himself up for her. He died for her. He washed her. He is actively working to present her to himself in splendor, holy and blameless. This is not passive affection. This is not providing financially and calling it love. This is not occasional kindness and expecting gratitude. This is the most costly, self giving, sanctifying, other centered love in the universe. And Paul says: husband, that is your assignment.

Notice what Christ's love produces: the church is sanctified. Cleansed. Made holy. Presented in splendor. What does your love produce in your wife? Is she flourishing because of how you love her? Is she growing? Is she more secure? More seen? More known? Does she know she is cherished?

Two words. Nourish. To bring to full development. To invest in the growth and flourishing of your wife. To help her become everything God created her to be. Cherish. To warm. To protect. To hold tenderly. The image is of holding something precious close, shielding it from damage.

ἀγαπάω (agapaō), "Love," not eros (romantic love) or phileo (brotherly affection), but agape: the deliberate, covenantal, sacrificial choosing of another person's good above your own. This is not a love that depends on how you feel. It is a love that acts consistently, sacrificially, regardless of whether it is returned or even recognized.

Your marriage is a sermon. Make sure it is preaching the right gospel.

REFLECT

Sit with this: Your marriage is a sermon. Make sure it is preaching the right gospel.

The Profound Mystery

Paul quotes Genesis 2:24, the oldest institution in human history. And then he says: this was always about something more than marriage.

From the very beginning, when God created the first husband and wife and said the two shall become one flesh, He was writing a story. A parable embedded in creation itself. A story about a Bridegroom who would leave His Father's house, pursue a bride who was not worthy of Him, give Himself entirely for her, and make her one with Himself.

That is what marriage is for. Not just companionship. Not just family. Not just the foundation of society. Marriage is a living, daily, embodied proclamation of the gospel.

Every time a husband loves his wife sacrificially, the world gets a picture of how Jesus loves His church. Every time a wife honors and trusts her husband, the world gets a picture of how the church trusts and follows Christ. This is why marriage matters. This is why the enemy attacks it so relentlessly. He knows what it is preaching.

REFLECT

What is God saying to you in this? Write it down before you move on.

A PRAYER OF IDENTITY

Father, thank You that I am Your beloved child. Help me imitate You, not through straining, but through staying close. Fill me with Your Spirit continuously, not just on Sundays, but in the Monday ordinary. Wake me up where I have drifted. Help me walk carefully, making the best use of every moment You have given me. For those of us who are married, make our homes a living picture of Christ and His church. May our love preach the gospel. In Jesus' name, Amen.

CLOSING DECLARATION

I am an imitator of God as His beloved child!

I walk in love, the kind that gives itself up!

I am light in the Lord and I walk as a child of light!

I make no peace with the works of darkness. I expose them by shining!

I am awake, not drifting, not sleeping, not numb. I am alive and producing fruit!

I am filled with the Spirit continuously, not occasionally, and that filling overflows in worship, in gratitude, and in love for the people around me!

I walk carefully, making the best use of every moment God has given me!

My marriage is a living picture of Christ and His church and I take that calling seriously!

I walk with victory, not to it. Amen!

Stand

EPHESIANS 6:1 TO 24

From the heavenly places to the household to the battlefield.

Six weeks. One letter. One story. We started in the heavenly places, chosen, blessed, and seated with Christ before the foundation of the world. We moved through the grave and the resurrection. We saw the mystery revealed. We heard the therefore. Walk worthy. Put off the old. Walk in love, in light, in wisdom. Be filled with the Spirit.

And now Paul ends his letter. He does not end in the heavenly places. He ends in the household. And then on the battlefield. Because the letter that began with the highest possible vision of who you are in Christ has always been aimed at one thing: how you live. In your family. In your work. In the war that is happening whether you acknowledge it or not.

This is a five-day devotional, one day per movement. Carry it through the week.

"Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might. Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the schemes of the devil... and having done all, to stand firm."

Honor Is More Than Obedience

"Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right. 'Honor your father and mother' (this is the first commandment with a promise), 'that it may go well with you and that you may live long in the land.' Fathers, do not provoke your children to anger, but bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord." Ephesians 6:1 to 4 · ESV

The letter that started in the heavenly places lands here. In the household. Paul could have ended Ephesians with a flourish, a theological crescendo, a final brilliant doctrine. Instead he ends with children and parents. Because the God who seated you above every principality also walks with you through every ordinary Tuesday morning.

Paul uses two words worth distinguishing. Obey and honor. They are not the same. Obeying means doing what you are told. Honoring means treating someone like they genuinely matter. You can comply externally while holding contempt internally. Paul calls for both the action and the posture behind it.

τιμάω (timaō), to prize, to esteem as genuinely valuable. Not mere compliance. It carries the idea of ascribing worth to a person. Honor flows from reverence for God, not just duty to the person. And Paul adds the phrase in the Lord as the governing frame. Not blind obedience to every word a parent speaks. Honor that flows from your relationship with Christ. This posture does not expire at age eighteen. It changes expression. The posture remains

To fathers Paul gives equally pointed instruction. Two ways to provoke: severity without love, which produces children who feel they can never be enough. And absence without accountability, which produces children who feel they do not matter. Both wound. Both are provocation. But Paul does not stop at what not to do. He says what to do.

ἐκτρέφω (ektrephō), to bring up, to nourish. The same word Paul used in Ephesians 5:29 for how Christ nourishes the church. Fathers are called to parent the way Christ cares for His bride. Not with domination but with nourishment. Not with tyranny but with formation aimed at flourishing

Your household is a theology lesson whether you intend it to be or not. The question is what it is teaching.

REFLECT

Is there a relationship at home where you are honoring on the outside but holding something else on the inside? What would it look like to honor from the heart this week?

Where did your own upbringing shape how you lead at home? Is there a pattern that needs to stop with you?

Are the children in your care growing under your leadership, or straining under it? What would nourishment look like instead of provocation this week?

Your Real Audience

"...not by way of eye-service, as people-pleasers, but as bondservants of Christ, doing the will of God from the heart, rendering service with a good will as to the Lord and not to man, knowing that whatever good anyone does, this he will receive back from the Lord, whether he is a bondservant or is free." Ephesians 6:6 to 8 · ESV

Paul is writing to people who were actual slaves in the Roman Empire. People with no rights, no pay, no recourse. That is the weight of this context. And still he says: do it as unto Christ. If the principle holds in that extreme a situation, it holds in every workplace in every generation.

ὀφθαλμοδουλία (ophthalmodoulia), eye-service. A compound of ophthalmos (eye) and douleia (service). Working only when someone is watching. Paul may have coined this word. It did not likely exist before he wrote it. That is how precisely he identifies this behavior, and how seriously he takes the contrast between performing for people and working from the heart as unto the Lord

You have a different audience. Not the manager who cycles through every few years. Not the performance review. Not the coworker who may or may not notice your integrity. Christ. The One who sees everything and forgets nothing. The Monday morning meeting, the project nobody will praise, the task that goes entirely unacknowledged: do it as unto the Lord.

God is keeping the accounts. The work you do with integrity when no one is watching. He sees it. He records it. It will not be lost.

Verse 9 turns to those in authority. Do not threaten. Do not wield your position as a weapon. Your Master is in heaven, and there is no partiality with Him. Your authority is borrowed. You will give account

for how you used it. Did the people in your care flourish under your leadership or were they diminished by it?

REFLECT

When does your work ethic change based on who is watching? What specific task this week can you do as unto the Lord instead of for the audience in the room?

What would shift if you genuinely believed God was recording every act of faithfulness you do in obscurity?

If you lead people: are they flourishing or diminished under your leadership? How did you use your authority this past week?

Know Your Real Enemy

"For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the cosmic powers over this present darkness, against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places." Ephesians 6:12 · ESV

The person who hurt you is not your real enemy. The circumstance pressing in is not your real enemy. The institution opposing you is not your real enemy. There is a spiritual dimension behind the visible world. Rulers. Authorities. Cosmic powers over this present darkness. Spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places. Paul names it without flinching. This is organized, strategic, purposeful opposition.

πάλη (palē), hand-to-hand combat, wrestling. The most intimate and exhausting form of fighting. Paul does not say we observe the war from a comfortable distance. We are in it. Up close. But we are not unarmed. And we are not fighting alone

The enemy's attacks take many forms: doubt, temptation, accusation, fear, confusion, discouragement. When you misidentify the source, you spend your energy on flesh and blood while the real battle goes unfought. You get angry at people. You get paralyzed by circumstance. You waste your resources on things that are not the actual problem.

The enemy is not confused about who you are in Christ. His strategy is to make you forget it. Every lie is aimed at your identity first.

Paul's command is not to be paralyzed by fear. He names the enemy so you can engage clearly. Be strong, not in your own resources, not in your track record, not in your willpower. In the Lord. In the strength of His might. The same power that raised Christ from the dead is the power available to you now.

REFLECT

Where have you been fighting the wrong enemy? Spending energy on a person or circumstance instead of the spiritual force behind it?

What form is the enemy's attack taking in your life right now? Doubt? Accusation? Fear? Temptation? Name it specifically.

What does "be strong in the Lord, not in your own strength" look like in your practical situation this week?

God's Provision for the Battle

"Therefore take up the whole armor of God, that you may be able to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand firm."

Ephesians 6:13 · ESV

Whole. Not some of it. Not the comfortable pieces. The whole armor. And notice whose armor this is: the armor of God. Not armor you built through spiritual discipline or earned through faithful service. God's armor. Issued to you by the Commander Himself.

The Belt of Truth was the foundation piece of Roman armor. Without it, nothing else held together. Truth is what holds the spiritual life together. When you know who you are in Christ, when that truth is fastened at the core, lies have nowhere to take hold. Fasten it every morning before the day makes its claims.

The Breastplate of Righteousness protected the vital organs. The righteousness Paul has in view is Christ's, credited to your account at salvation. Romans 8:1: there is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. The enemy cannot successfully accuse a breastplate made of Christ's own righteousness. The breastplate holds.

The Shoes of the Gospel of Peace refer to the Roman soldier's studded sandals that gave traction on any terrain. The gospel-shod believer moves through difficult territory with readiness and stability. Wherever your foot lands, you carry good news.

πίστις The Shield of Faith. (pistis), active trust, reliance on the living God. Not passive belief in abstract propositions but the posture of the whole person toward Him. The shield is raised by a decision, not a feeling. You choose to trust what God said even when the enemy is firing doubt, accusation, temptation, or fear in your direction

The Helmet of Salvation protected the mind. The enemy targets your thinking above almost everything else. If he can produce sustained

confusion, shame, or hopelessness in your thought life, the battle is effectively over. The helmet is the settled knowledge of who you are, whose you are, and how the story ends. When you know the end, the middle chapters cannot undo you.

ῥῆμα The Sword of the Spirit. (rhēma), the spoken, active declaration in a specific moment against a specific attack. The only offensive weapon in the entire list. Jesus used it in the wilderness. Every temptation: It is written. He did not argue with the enemy. He declared. The enemy had nothing left. This is why spoken declaration matters: it is the sword of the Spirit wielded in real time against a real attack

REFLECT

Which piece of the armor have you been consistently neglecting? What would it look like to put it on deliberately every morning this week?

What specific lie is currently targeting your mind? What specific verse is the sword that cuts through it? Say it out loud today.

The breastplate is Christ's righteousness, not yours. Where have you been trying to stand in your own performance instead of in what He has already done?

Having Done All. Stand.

"Peace be to the brothers, and love with faith, from God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. Grace be with all who love our Lord Jesus Christ with love incorruptible." Ephesians 6:23 to 24 · ESV

Paul uses the word stand four times in this passage. Stand. Withstand. Stand firm. Stand therefore. It is the most repeated word in the entire closing section. And it is a declaration: I refuse to retreat. I refuse to be moved from the ground Christ has purchased. Whatever is coming. I hold my position.

Notice that Paul does not add prayer as the seventh piece of armor. Prayer is the atmosphere in which the armor functions. A soldier can be fully equipped and still lose if he is not in communication with his Commander. The armor keeps you standing. Prayer keeps you connected to the One who has already won. Praying at all times in the Spirit: all kinds of prayer. Intercession. Declaration. Warfare. Thanksgiving. The whisper at 3 a.m. when words cannot be found. All of it. All the time.

The resurrection was not the beginning of the fight. It was the end of it. You are not fighting toward a victory that has not yet happened. You are standing in a victory that has already been won.

Then Paul asks for prayer himself. The man who received the revelation of Ephesians. The man who wrote the most elevated theological letter in the New Testament says: pray for me. No one is too seasoned to need the intercession of the church. If Paul needed it, so do you. And so does the person beside you. We hold the line for one another.

And the final word of the entire letter is grace. The same word that opened Ephesians 1:2 closes it here in 6:24. Six chapters. From the heavenly places to the household to the battlefield. Paul brings it

home with grace. Everything he has written, the election, the adoption, the seating, the mystery, the worthy walk, the armor, all of it is grace. From first to last. Not earned. Not maintained by performance. Grace, freely given.

The love in verse 24 is described as incorruptible. ἀφθαρσία (aphtharsiai): imperishable, not subject to decay. It does not fade when circumstances are hard or feelings are cold or the battle is long. That is the love with which God loves you. Unchanging. From before the foundation of the world to the last page of Revelation. Stand in it. Walk in it. Live from it.

REFLECT

What would it mean to stand in your current situation rather than retreat or strive harder in your own strength? What does that look like specifically this week?

Who in your life are you actively holding the line for in prayer? Is there someone you need to begin interceding for by name?

After six weeks in Ephesians, from the heavenly places to the household to the battlefield: which revelation has most changed the way you see yourself in Christ?

CLOSING DECLARATION

Father, thank You that I am strong in You and in the strength of Your might. Not my resources. Not my willpower. Yours. Help me honor the people You placed in my life. Help me work from the heart as unto Christ, not as a people-pleaser, but as a bondservant of Christ. Open my eyes to the real battle so I stop wasting energy fighting the wrong enemy. Help me put on the whole armor. Every piece. Every morning. And help me stand. Not strive. Not perform. Stand. On ground Christ already purchased. On a victory He secured on a cross and confirmed in an empty tomb. I hold the line for the people around me. Your grace covers what my effort cannot. In Jesus' name, Amen.

I am chosen before the foundation of the world. I am raised from the dead and seated in heavenly places. I am God's workmanship, walking in works He prepared. I honor in my household and work as unto the Lord. I know my real enemy and I fight the right battle. I wear the whole armor of God. Every piece. Every day. The belt is fastened. The breastplate holds. The shield is raised. The helmet is secured. The sword of the Spirit is in my hand. I pray at all times. I hold the line for those I love. Having done everything. I stand. The ground belongs to Christ and I will not surrender it. Grace be with all who love our Lord Jesus Christ. I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name.

Now go. Standing in the strength of His might. Dressed in the armor He provided. Connected to the Commander who never loses. May the God who chose you before the foundation of the world remind you this week that you are not fighting for survival. You are standing in a victory He secured on a cross and confirmed in an empty tomb. May your household be a place of honor. May you carry the work ethic of a bondservant

of Christ into every Monday. May the belt of truth hold everything together when lies rise. May the breastplate of Christ's righteousness shut down every accusation. May the sword of the Spirit cut through every deception. Pray at all times. Hold the line for one another. Stand. Grace be with you.

THE EPHESIANS DECREE

Drawn from the closing declarations of all six weeks. Read it out loud.

Decrees are not whispered.

I am chosen in Christ before the foundation of the world.

I am blessed with every spiritual blessing in heavenly places. I am adopted as a son of the living God. I am redeemed according to the riches of His grace, not the poverty of my performance.

My identity is in Christ Jesus, settled before time began.

I was dead. I was far off. I was without hope.

But God, rich in mercy, brought me near by the blood of His Son.

I did not earn this. I could not earn this. I receive it. I am no longer a stranger. I am no longer an outsider. I am a citizen of His kingdom, a member of His household, a living stone in His holy temple. The blood is enough. The blood has always been enough.

The mystery of Christ is in me and I am in Him.

I am a fellow heir, a member of His body, a partaker of the promise. I am filled, not halfway, not enough to get by, but with all the fullness of God. My God is able to do far more abundantly than everything I have asked or imagined, according to His power that is already at work within me.

I walk worthy of my calling, not to earn it, but because of it.

I maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace. I put off the old self. It has no dominion over me. I am renewed in the spirit of my mind by the Word of God. I put on the new self, not a better version of me, but Christ formed in me. I do not grieve

the One who sealed me into covenant. The Christian life is not behavior modification. It is identity manifestation.

I am an imitator of God as His beloved child.

I walk in love, the kind that gives itself up. I am light in the Lord and I walk as a child of light. I make no peace with the works of darkness. I expose them by shining. I am awake, not drifting, not sleeping, not numb. I am alive and producing fruit. I am filled with the Spirit continuously, not occasionally, and that filling overflows in worship, in gratitude, and in love for the people around me.

I know my real enemy and I fight the right battle.

I wear the whole armor of God. Every piece. Every day. The belt is fastened. The breastplate holds. The shield is raised. The helmet is secured. The sword of the Spirit is in my hand. I pray at all times. I hold the line for those I love. Having done everything, I stand. The ground belongs to Christ and I will not surrender it.

Grace be with all who love our Lord Jesus Christ.

I walk with victory, not to it, in Jesus' name.

Amen!

THE GATHERING CTX
Cleburne, Texas · gatheringctx.org

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